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Original Page: 253**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1958-1966**Coverage Date:** 1958-1966**Place Coverage:** G/Wi, Ghanzi District, Botswana**Section Title(S):** Economic Choice

His fourth point is hedged with qualification: first, that it is concerned with staple foodstuffs and, second, that these foods are given in expression of sociability, which Sahlins does not see as falling within the economic ambit. It seems to me that such exclusion is contradicted both by his definition of "economy" and, to some extent, by his subsequent (145 ff.) discussion of balanced reciprocity in such contexts as friendship, expression of corporate status, alliances, and so on.

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With some reservations, Sahlins's hypotheses are confirmed by the G/wi case. Reciprocity is, indeed, more frequently generalized among close, rather than distant, kin. It is unequivocally generalized between, say, parents and children where reciprocation is not so much back to the givers as onward to the next generation. Grown children return less to their aged parents than they received from them during the years of dependence but give to their own children what they received from their parents. Beyond this range, extending to independent siblings, joking partners, and even to initiation mates, the reciprocation of exchanges is not balanced between giver and recipient by a matching return by the latter. However, within the circle of generalized reciprocity, there is a tendency to overall balance between what an individual gives and what he eventually receives from whomever in the circle. This is not to deny Sahlins but to lend point to his statement that reciprocity is "a continuum of forms" (1965:144).

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Furthermore, generalized and balanced reciprocity are not mutually exclusive. As Sahlins indicated (1965:152), certain modes are dominant in particular sectors. In the G/wi case the practice of generalized reciprocity between all

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but very close kin does not preclude concomitant exchanges in the balanced mode.

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Kinship ranking is virtually restricted to the parent-child relationship and to that between a wife's parents and their son-in-law. In the former case the flow of goods is downward. The latter case is somewhat anomalous: The preponderance of goods flows from the son-in-law to the wife's parents. Although it is convenient to refer to this  254 phenomenon as groom service, suggesting that the flow of goods represents the marriage prestation and, hence, balanced reciprocity, the arrangement is not regarded as contractual by G/wi informants. In their view the husband makes his gifts to demonstrate his ability as a hunter and provider and also as tokens of his respect for his wife's parents. The extent and exact nature of the gifts are not specified beyond the notion that a son-in-law should make a present of meat, skins, or other commodities at least once a year. It seems, therefore, that this has more the character of generalized reciprocity up the scale of kinship ranking, rather than the balanced reciprocity of the marriage prestation — giving meat and so on, in return for the wife whom he received from her parents.

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